his father's script as "emotional", and he found himself crying many times.

Not every political film finds backers. *Gandhi vs Godse* was one. Writer-director Rajkumar Santoshi found few producers for his film, a fictional verbal face-off between the two eponymous characters. "They didn't want to touch it," he told INDIA TODAY in January, worried about the "controversy". Santoshi's attempt to give Gandhi's assassin, Nathuram Godse, a voice failed to make a dent at the box office, especially since it was up against Shah Rukh Khan's nation-loving spy *Pathaan*. "His [Godse's] voice was suppressed," he said. "Reject it if you don't like his opinion, but his voice has to be heard." It didn't come at the cost of negating Gandhi's contribution to India's freedom movement. Interestingly, Gandhi will be the focus of the Applause Entertainment-produced as yet unnamed web series on Gandhi. Based on historian Ramachandra Guha's books, it will be directed by Hansal Mehta and have Pratik Gandhi (of *Scam 1992: The Harshad Mehta Story*) playing the iconic leader.

Committing to a role took on a whole new dimension for Kangana Ranaut, who played the political figure of J. Jayalalithaa in the box office failure *Thalaivi*. The actress says she mortgaged all her properties to make a film about one of the "most powerful and controversial women in the history of the world"—Indira Gandhi. "Emergency reflects one of the most important periods in Indian political history, which changed the way we view power," said Ranaut in a media statement, "and that's why I decided to tell this story." The political drama stars Anupam Kher as Jayaprakash Narayan, Shreyas Talpade as Atal Bihari Vajpayee, Mahima Chaudhary as Pupul Jayakar and late Satish Kaushik as Jagjivan Ram.

Ranaut isn't the only actor on double duty: sitting in the director's chair and donning prosthetics to look the part. Hooda lost 22 kg and has devoted some two years of his life to the Savarkar film. "Sometimes I feel it is not me but the man himself who has chosen you," Hooda told INDIA TODAY in December 2022 in the midst of shooting. "It is definitely stretching my imagination and physical and mental ability to do all three in the same film."

Producer Sandip Singh, who has invested in both the Vajpayee and Savarkar films, attributes the rise in political dramas to how politically aware the nation has become in the past few years. That awakening has come through news channels and social media where politics guarantees TRPs and trends respectively. "Every family wants to know what is happening in politics," he says. "The stories are inspiring, and stoke nationalism and patriotism." The larger-than-life personality of the two men offers an opportunity to do exactly that.

Singh describes Vajpayee as "the only politician who was loved by the opposition more" than perhaps his own party. With Savarkar, he hoped, the film will "awaken mindsets about a misunderstood hero", adding that "just because of one party [Congress], you cannot sabotage a person who fought for India's freedom and formed the RSS." He and the co-producers are well aware of the sensitivity and responsibility of telling the story of their lives. "We are being extremely careful and paying attention to every minute detail. Be it visual or costume, it shouldn't go wrong," says Singh.

In Hooda and Tripathi, the film has talented actors who savour the process of sinking into the characters. "It is an iconic role for both of them," he says. "They are both passionate actors, respected for their craft and selective. They give 100 per cent to the character they play." He hopes the films do well enough to encourage big production houses to invest in the lesser-seen genre. Whether that happens or not, audiences can expect inspiring speeches and behind-the-scenes dramas on the big screen. ■



HUMBLE POLITICIANN NOGRAJ *(Voot Select)*

Danish Sait is a riot as he reprises the character he made famous on social media and later in a Kannada feature. The web series documents the misadventures of a self-obsessed, power-hungry politician, from a fictitious party of course.

QUEEN *(MX Player)*

Loosely based on the life of former Tamil Nadu CM J. Jayalalitha, the Tamil-language series documents a woman's journey from leading star to the highest echelon of state politics. Created by Gautham Menon and Prasath Murugesan, it stars Ramya Krishnan as Jaya.



COMMITTING TO A ROLE HAS TAKEN A NEW DIMENSION FOR KANGANA RANAUT. SHE HAS MORTGAGED PROPERTY IN ORDER TO MAKE *EMERGENCY*